

Teaching Statement

As a teacher of Political Science, my goal is to help my students succeed in the course itself, engage in respectful and fruitful discussion with others, and draw connections between the course materials and real-world events. To achieve these three intertwined objectives, I strive to establish clear expectations in my teaching, aid my students develop their arguments and thinking through Socratic debates, and present a selection of current events to bring theoretical concepts from the course to life. As a teacher, I am also keenly aware of the diversity of backgrounds and perspectives assembled in the classroom and I strongly encourage my students to draw on their own experiences in the class discussions.

Teaching Expectations

As a teacher, I am convinced that the best way to ensure that my students have an enriching and productive learning experience is through establishing clear expectations and classroom policies. This is why, even before the first course meeting, I share a brief syllabus document with my students outlining the main assignments, classroom policies and deadlines. I provide these also for courses where I serve as a TA, so that my students have both the main course syllabus and a personalized syllabus for the section meetings with me. During the first class meeting I go over this document with my students, explain how grading, office hours and other class logistics work, and answer student questions. Additionally, as the semester goes on, I make a point of reminding my students of upcoming deadlines and other important items required for the class. I also explicitly encourage students to attend my office hours and/or reach out to me via email in case of any questions and/or concerns. This might appear obvious, but I found that some students reach out or come to my office hours only after a second or third reminder from me that these resources are in place for them and their learning needs.

Engaged and Respectful Discussion

College classrooms offer rare and unique experience for students to engage in thoughtful and critical debate with both their peers and their professors. Undoubtedly, this can be a challenging experience, which is why encourage my students to “disagree with the opinions of other students, not the students themselves.” I think this is an important distinction that aspires to blunt the personal elements of in-class disagreements. I also do this from my own position as a teacher – instead of imposing my own political views on the topics at hand, I aim to provide an even-handed account and bring in a diversity of viewpoints and perspectives. In doing so, I often assume the role of “devil’s advocate” in countering my students’ arguments, which in turn forces them to improve the defense of their own positions. As I guide my students through conversations with their peers, I ensure that the expressed opinions of individual students are tied to one another and draw in other students as well. Finally, I also see great value in turning the table and asking my students to tell me why I had them do certain activity. This type of debriefs helps the students to understand, in their own words, the value and purpose of in-class discussions. Additionally, the studied concepts and theories “sink in” far more this way, in my own pedagogical experience.

Connecting the Classroom to the World

Whether it’s Empirical Methods or Introduction to IR, nothing brings the concepts to life more than seeing them play out in real-life, contemporaneous events. That is, in my mind, the ultimate benefit of teaching Political Science courses as there is never a shortage of relevant developments both within the US and globally. Thus, I devote substantial portions of my class time to discussing current events with my students. I do so by putting up select photos on the projector and first asking my students to describe the shown event in their own words. Then we collectively discuss how the concepts from the class apply to this political event and what do these theories tell us about the future development of these. I find this to be a priceless opportunity to connect the theory to the real world. For example, when I TA-ed for Introduction to IR in Winter of 2025, my students had even more opportunities to see the real-life workings of IR theories than usual: the erosion of the norms against territorial conquest (Russia in Ukraine and Trump’s threats against both Greenland and Panama), multi-agent bargaining and game theory (the second ceasefire between

Hamas and Israel), and the downward spiral of global trade war (US' "retaliatory" tariffs on just about every country in the world), to name only a few. I especially enjoy seeing my students have the "eureka" moments when they draw the connections between their class lectures and the big news headlines they have seen and read.

Conclusion

While the pedagogical objectives and strategies described above describe the benefits for the students in my courses, I myself also benefit greatly from these teaching experiences, and I think this is an important part of what makes teaching important and worthwhile for me. As I prepare for my lectures, I have the rare opportunity of (re)learning the class concepts and thinking about how to communicate these to others. I also genuinely enjoy meeting new students, establishing personal connections with them and, among others, discussing possible career paths with them both within and without academia. Finally, I believe that being a good teacher makes me a better researcher as well as I am asked to coherently and effectively organize and share my own interpretation of advanced concept and theories in Political Science to a broader audience.